

The launch as an instrument

Week 9, Lecture 2 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · UTM discipline, message match, burn risk

What we'll cover

- UTM discipline: why every link needs a tag and how to read the result
- Landing page message match: from post title to page headline to CTA
- Burn risk: the math that explains why LangoBee deferred launch correctly
- Launch as a repeatable instrument: the Manalac multi-phase framework
- The retention gate: what must be true before you drive volume
- This week's task: build the UTM set, check message match

UTM discipline

Why untagged links produce useless data

LangoBee's June 2026 acquisition breakdown: direct 174 (Discord recruiting), google.com 21, t.co 5. No attributed community traffic.

Without UTM tags, every community post looks like "direct" in PostHog. You cannot distinguish a Show HN visitor from a Discord DM.

UTM parameters tell PostHog where a visitor came from:

```
utm_source    = the platform (reddit, hackernews, discord)
utm_medium    = the content type (community, post, dm)
utm_campaign  = the specific launch event (wk09-show-hn, wk09-r-spanish)
```

One tagged link per community, per post, per week. This is how you know which community converted.

The UTM tagging standard for this launch

Every link you post this week gets a unique tag set:

Community	utm_source	utm_medium	utm_campaign
Show HN	hackernews	community	wk09-show-hn
r/languagelearning	reddit	community	wk09-r-ll
r/Spanish	reddit	community	wk09-r-spanish
r/dreamingspanish	reddit	community	wk09-r-ds

Read results in PostHog under Acquisition > Sources, filtered by utm_campaign. Give each community 7 days before comparing. (Alstromer, 2022)

Do not reuse tags across weeks. A tag from the week 9 launch and the week 11 launch must differ so you can compare performance over time.

Landing page message match

What message match means

Message match is the degree of continuity between the text that made a visitor click and the text they see after they land.

A visitor reads: "I built a Spanish video player that tracks every word you know."

They land on a page that says: "LangoBee: Learn Spanish faster."

The mismatch is not a visual problem. It is a trust problem. The visitor was promised a specific thing; they received a generic thing.

The conversion rate at this mismatch point drops immediately. A visitor who sees a generic headline after clicking on a specific promise has no reason to stay: the implicit contract made in the post was broken before the page loaded.

Matching title to page to CTA

The three-point chain for LangoBee's Show HN post:

1. **HN title:** "Show HN: LangoBee -- A Spanish video player that tracks your vocabulary as you watch"
2. **Landing page headline:** "Watch Spanish videos. Every word you know turns green."
3. **First CTA:** "Try with a free Spanish video" (not "Start free trial")

The CTA must not be a subscription prompt for a first-time Show HN visitor. They have not yet received the value. Demanding payment before the aha moment is the single most reliable way to produce a 100% bounce rate from a community launch.

The paywall comes after the `word_lookup_opened` event fires for the first time. Not before.

Burn risk

The math of driving traffic into a leaky product

LangoBee's June 2026 retention data: approximately 24% of real signups ever return. Median activated user has 1 active day and roughly 2 minutes of total session time.

If you drive 1,000 visitors from r/languagelearning into that product today:

```
1,000 visitors
x 10% signup rate      = 100 signups
x 24% ever-return      = 24 users who come back once
x ~5% trial-started    = 1-2 trial starts (optimistic)
```

The 976 visitors who did not convert are gone. The community post slot is used. The karma cost is paid. And the channel has seen LangoBee once, with a result that gives it no reason to mention it again.

Why the founder deferred this correctly

The June 1 week showed 52 apparent signups, 1 activated (bot-dominated cohort). The founder did not push a launch post that week. That was the right call.

The arithmetic from the previous slide explains why the deferral was correct: 1,000 visitors into a 24%-ever-return product produces roughly 24 users who return once. That is not an acquisition channel. It is an advertisement for a product that does not yet retain.

Burn risk is not fear of rejection. It is arithmetic. Sending traffic into a product that returns 24% of visitors wastes the channel. Communities remember bad experiences. r/languagelearning has 3.4M members who share notes.

The retention gate: what must be true before driving volume

Before running a volume-generating community post, two conditions must be true:

1. **Retention floor:** at least one cohort week (minimum 10 real users) shows a day-7 return rate above 30%. The May 18 cohort (6 of 15 returned later) is the closest signal -- 40%, but n=6.
2. **Must-work checklist:** the critical path from "Sign up" to "word_lookup_opened" runs without error for a first-time user from a mobile browser. Run it before each launch post.

The must-work checklist from week 3 is a launch precondition, not a one-time task. Re-run it the morning of any launch post. (Seibel, 2019 -- cited via wk03 section)

Launch as a repeatable instrument

The Manalac multi-launch framework

Kat Manalac's core argument: founders make a mistake treating launch as a singular high-stakes event. Every launch is a test, and tests are repeatable.

Four phases, each targeting a distinct audience with distinct message-match:

1. **Soft launch:** close network, Discord (30 people -- LangoBee has this)
2. **Community launch:** HN, r/dreamingspanish (small, high-fit) -- this week
3. **Broader community:** r/languagelearning, r/Spanish -- after retention gate
4. **Press/creator launch:** after a validated conversion rate exists

Each phase produces data: which channel sent users, how many activated, how many returned, what they said. That data informs the next phase. (Manalac, 2019)

What makes a launch repeatable

A launch becomes an instrument when it produces a reading you can act on.

Three conditions for a readable launch:

1. **UTM tags on every link.** Otherwise the PostHog source breakdown is noise.
2. **Consistent message.** Different posts in the same week must carry the same core claim so you can attribute conversions to the channel, not to copy variation.
3. **A pre-set observation window.** Decide in advance: you will read results 7 days after the post. Not 24 hours. Not 30 days.

Weinberg's Bullseye framework: each channel test costs under \$1,000 and runs under one month. The community launch is the cheapest test available -- it costs only time and preparation. (Weinberg, 2015)

Founders should think about launching as something they do again and again, not as a singular high-stakes event. (Paraphrased)

Kat Manalac, Y Combinator (2019)

How to Launch (Again and Again)

Take-aways

1. UTM tags are not optional. Every link you post to a community this week gets a unique tag. Without them, PostHog cannot tell you which community converted.
2. Message match is the three-point chain: post title, landing page headline, first CTA. A mismatch at any point costs conversions that cannot be recovered.
3. Burn risk is arithmetic: sending 1,000 visitors into a 24%-ever-return product produces 24 users who return once. The channel is not free to use again.
4. The retention gate must clear before a volume-generating launch. One cohort week above 30% day-7 return, and the must-work checklist passing on mobile.
5. A launch is an instrument when it produces a reading: tagged source, consistent message, pre-set observation window. Repeat it; do not treat it as a one-time event.

What's next

- **Reading:** "Week 9: Community launch and channel fit" at </c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk09>
- **Section this week:** Draft the Reddit post and Show HN post; pre-mortem the top ten hostile comments; run the must-work checklist
- **HW4 "The launch and the creator wave" goes OUT this week**
- **Week 10:** Creator partnerships -- outreach, deal structure, equity vs affiliate